

Knowledge sharing of inpatriates

Empirical evidence from an ability–motivation–opportunity perspective

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Abstract

Purpose – The purpose of this study is to analyze the effects of inpatriates' abilities, motivation and opportunities on knowledge sharing and the moderating role of boundary spanning in this context.

Design/methodology/approach – By integrating the ability–motivation–opportunity framework with the concept of boundary spanning four hypotheses are developed, which are tested against the data of 187 inpatriates working in Germany.

Findings – The study reveals that inpatriates' motivation and certain opportunities are positively related to knowledge sharing, whereas inpatriates' abilities do not show a positive effect. Moreover, it is shown that inpatriate boundary spanning has a moderating effect on this relationship.

Originality/value – Based on the results, the study enhances the current literature by introducing the concept of reputation asymmetry. Moreover, requirements of how inpatriates' assignments should be designed and implications for further research are outlined.

Keywords International assignments, Ability-motivation-opportunity framework, Knowledge sharing, Boundary spanning, Inpatriation, Reputation asymmetry

Paper type Research paper

1. Introduction

International assignments are important means of knowledge transfers within multinational corporations (MNCs) as they are able to translate culturally instilled knowledge from one context to another (Iles *et al.*, 2004; Minbaeva and Michailova, 2004). While MNCs had mainly focused on headquarters' (HQs) delegates who transfer knowledge to foreign subsidiaries (expatriates) (Chang *et al.*, 2012; Harzing, 2001; Hocking *et al.*, 2007; Minbaeva *et al.*, 2014), they have increasingly recognized the importance of knowledge creation capabilities of their foreign subsidiaries (Colakoglu *et al.*, 2014) to withstand the hyper-competitive nature of global markets (Moeller and Reiche, 2017). To exploit those knowledge creation capabilities, MNCs have progressively introduced alternative staffing options, including flexpatriation (Mayerhofer, Hartmann and Herbert, 2004; Mayerhofer, Hartmann, Michelitsch-Riedl and Kollinger, 2004), international business travels (Welch *et al.*, 2007), virtual assignments (Welch *et al.*, 2003) and inpatriation (Harvey *et al.*, 2011; Harvey, Speier and Novicevic, 1999; Harvey and Buckley, 1997). In particular, inpatriation – assignees recruited from MNCs' subsidiaries or other third countries to work in HQ locations over varying timeframes for various purposes and on varying levels of management (Moeller *et al.*, 2016; Reiche, 2011) – is of particular relevance for disseminating knowledge created in the MNC's foreign subsidiaries because these employees are not only familiar with the subsidiary's products, processes and customers, but often possess a dense personal network in their home organization and society (Moeller *et al.*, 2016). This makes inpatriates valuable resources regarding reverse innovations



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and technology transfers from their subsidiaries to the HQ (e.g. knowledge transfer agents) (Håkanson and Nobel, 2000; Yang *et al.*, 2008).

While the global mobility literature is replete with research on expatriates and their value to MNCs, research on inpatriates is still very fragmented and has only received limited attention (Moeller and Reiche, 2017). During the past two decades, several researchers have broadened the perspective of global mobility by studying the inpatriate phenomenon, which reflects the increasing practical relevance of this employee group (Collings *et al.*, 2010; Gertsen and Söderberg, 2012; Harvey, 1997; Harvey, Novicevic and Speier, 1999; Harvey, Speier and Novicevic, 1999; Harvey and Buckley, 1997; Maley and Moeller, 2018; Moeller *et al.*, 2010; Reiche, 2006, 2011; Tungli and Peiperl, 2009).

These researchers consistently outline that despite similarities between expatriates and inpatriates, differences along numerous dimensions and additional challenges, compared to their expatriate counterparts, are apparent (Mäkelä *et al.*, 2012; Maley and Moeller, 2018). For instance, Harvey *et al.* (2005) emphasize a deep-rooted resistance toward the integration of inpatriates in the home-country organization, which is often transmuted into silent but concerted customs of ethnocentric stigmatization and stereotyping. This “collective reservation” toward inpatriates (Harvey *et al.*, 2005) particularly occurs in HQs when the inpatriates come from peripheral units, technologically less-advanced countries, developing economies and less important markets (Moeller *et al.*, 2016). Moreover, inpatriates may also face organizational barriers, such as language problems or a lack of management attention, which may reduce their efforts to share knowledge (Chen *et al.*, 2010; Peltokorpi, 2015). Finally, inpatriates frequently receive less organizational support in the form of intercultural training or mentoring, which impedes their cultural adjustment to the host country and host organization (Maley *et al.*, 2015).

Given these opportunities and challenges of this valuable group of assignees, MNCs seek to understand how inpatriates’ efforts to share knowledge from the subsidiary to the HQ can be increased. While previous literature has already provided initial evidence that inpatriates and expatriates should be treated differently (Maley and Moeller, 2018) and outlined distinctive features of inpatriates as agents of knowledge transfer (Reiche, 2006, 2011; Reiche, Kraimer and Harzing, 2009), we still have a limited understanding whether inpatriates’ efforts to share knowledge are primarily promoted by individual characteristics, such as inpatriates’ international work experience, motivation or by organizational support offered by the home and host organization – factors that have been frequently mentioned in the expatriation context. Moreover, although boundary spanning is seen as an important aspect of inpatriation (Reiche, 2011) and knowledge sharing (Barner-Rasmussen *et al.*, 2014), the role of inpatriate boundary spanning as a moderator in this context is yet to be examined. Boundary spanning is defined as the activity to link and establish relationships between previously unconnected individuals at different MNC units (Barner-Rasmussen *et al.*, 2014; Monteiro and Birkinshaw, 2016; Reiche, 2011). As inpatriates often serve as boundary spanners in the context of knowledge transfers – it is argued in this study that inpatriates abilities, motivation and opportunities may have different effects on knowledge sharing depending on the level of their boundary spanning activity. Therefore, this study extends on previous studies and aims to explore and provide empirical evidence on the question of how inpatriates’ abilities, motivation and opportunities affect knowledge sharing and how inpatriate boundary spanning moderates this relationship. By doing so, the study responds to recent calls for empirical research on inpatriates as the emerging body of literature on inpatriation remains largely conceptual (Maley and Moeller, 2018).

As a theoretical foundation, the study applies the ability–motivation–opportunity (AMO) framework. This framework is considered to be highly suitable for analyzing inpatriates’ knowledge sharing because it addresses both individual characteristics (e.g. host-country language skills) and organizational processes (e.g. organizational support) which have been

revealed as main determinants of knowledge sharing in previous studies (Feldman and Bolino, 1999; Peltokorpi, 2015; Reiche, 2011). However, as the AMO framework mainly focuses on the agents of knowledge transfer (i.e. inpatriates and employees of the home and host organization), the relationships between these agents are not explicitly conceptualized. Therefore, this study extends previous research by combining the AMO framework with the concept of boundary spanning.

To realize our research objectives the study proceeds as follows: first, the current state of research on inpatriation, knowledge sharing and boundary spanning will be illustrated as well as the theoretical framework will be outlined. Next, our research model and hypotheses are to be presented. Subsequently, we outline the methodological procedure before the results are presented and discussed. Finally, we are reflecting on contributions, limitations and implications of our study.

2. Theory and hypothesis

2.1 Theoretical background

Inpatriation among other staffing options plays an important role in the creation of a beneficial global mobility mix of MNCs, which helps them to withstand the hyper-competitive nature of global markets. However, inpatriates and the management of this global staffing mechanism are still insufficiently explored and companies need a better understanding of the value that such individuals can bring and the challenges they face (Moeller and Reiche, 2017). Inpatriates are defined as assignees who are recruited from MNCs' subsidiaries or other third countries to work in HQ locations over varying timeframes for various purposes across different management levels (Moeller *et al.*, 2016; Reiche, 2011). This broad definition reflects the different conceptualizations that exist in the extant inpatriate literature (Maley and Moeller, 2018; Reiche, 2011). Whereas Harvey *et al.* (2005) and Harvey, Novicevic and Speier (1999) view inpatriation as semi-permanent to permanent relocations with the objective to build global management teams at the HQ, other scholars consider inpatriation as assignments of limited duration (three to five years) mainly for boundary spanning and knowledge transfer purposes (van der Heijden *et al.*, 2009; Peterson, 2003; Reiche, 2006, 2011; Shaffer *et al.*, 1999). It becomes apparent that these two streams look at different management levels when speaking of inpatriation. While the former consider experienced subsidiary managers or senior employees that joined the middle or top management in the HQ and who are responsible for long-term strategic decisions of the MNC (Maley and Moeller, 2018), the latter focus on lower management levels and specialized technical positions that are filled with foreign employees and managers who join the HQ for several years but will most likely return to their home units after they have completed their assignments. Analogously, Moeller *et al.* (2016) accentuate that the presence of inpatriates is widespread and covers varying levels of management, rather than being restricted to the top management. Consistent with our objectives and in line with previous research on inpatriate knowledge sharing (Harvey *et al.*, 2011; Reiche, Kraimer and Harzing, 2009), this study focuses on the latter and defines inpatriates as assignees from MNCs' subsidiaries, who are relocated to the HQ for a limited timeframe mainly for boundary spanning and knowledge transfer purposes.

Despite many similarities between inpatriates and parent country expatriates, the body of literature on inpatriation outlines differences between expatriates and inpatriates and specify additional challenges of inpatriates that might impede knowledge sharing (for an overview, please see Moeller *et al.*, 2016; Reiche, Kraimer and Harzing, 2009). First, whereas expatriates carry with them the status and reputation associated with their role as HQ representatives, inpatriates are perceived as outsiders or peripheral members by the HQ staff, which limit their influence and credibility in the host unit. Likewise, Harvey *et al.* (2005) refer to a "collective reservation" toward inpatriates of the HQ staff by outlining

customs of ethnocentric stigmatization and stereotyping, causing that inpatriates will have more difficulties and might need different abilities to prove their unique value for the MNC and to successfully share knowledge with the HQ staff. Second, regarding dissimilar adjustment processes between inpatriates and expatriates, previous inpatriate studies argue that inpatriates are not only confronted to adjust to the new national culture but also need to be socialized into the MNC's HQ corporate culture (Moeller *et al.*, 2010), which might cause additional barriers to knowledge sharing.

Despite the outlined differences that might have an impact on knowledge sharing processes, the inpatriate literature outline fundamental parallels between these employee groups concerning knowledge transfer processes. First, inpatriate scholars (e.g. Reiche, 2011; Reiche, Kraimer and Harzing, 2009) argue that knowledge is rooted in individuals (Felin and Hesterly, 2007) and that the individuals need the ability and willingness to engage in knowledge sharing (Minbaeva and Michailova, 2004). Second, it is argued that the process of transferring knowledge between individuals depends on social interaction, which means that individuals need opportunities to share their knowledge with others (Reiche, 2011). These two rationales are strongly reflected in the AMO framework, which suggests on a general level that ability, motivation and opportunity are the primary antecedents of successful task performance (Blumberg and Pringle, 1982; Campbell *et al.*, 1993). Ability covers an individual's knowledge, skills and experience that are needed to perform a task. Motivation refers to the individual's willingness to perform it. Opportunity represents the organizational mechanisms that enable task performance.

The AMO framework is well-established as a theoretical basis for the explanation of work performance (Blumberg and Pringle, 1982) and has been subsequently used to explain firm-level decision making (Wu *et al.*, 2004) and firm performance (Kim *et al.*, 2015). More recently, it has also been used to analyze knowledge-management practices in MNCs as knowledge has become more and more people-dependent (Chang *et al.*, 2012; Minbaeva *et al.*, 2003; Reinholt *et al.*, 2011). In line with the argumentation in the inpatriate literature and in accordance with the AMO framework it can be concluded that just as the successful performance of any task depends on the ability, motivation and opportunity, knowledge sharing is determined by the assignee's ability, motivation and opportunity (Argote *et al.*, 2003).

While the AMO framework is useful for conceptualizing antecedents of inpatriates as knowledge agents, the current literature on knowledge flows within MNCs argues that the relationships between foreign assignees and employees of the home and host organizations should also be considered. In particular, the role of boundary spanning in form of linking previously unconnected individuals and facilitating information flows between different organizational units has received large attention in this context (Au and Fukuda, 2002; Barner-Rasmussen *et al.*, 2014). Although boundary spanning is seen as a central influencing factor for successful knowledge transfers as it makes knowledge more widely available in an organization, little empirical evidence is available on this topic (Barner-Rasmussen *et al.*, 2014). To give more clarification on this issue, this study takes an alternative approach to Reiche (2011) by arguing that the effects of inpatriates' abilities, motivation and opportunities on knowledge sharing will vary as a function of inpatriate boundary spanning. In this study, we define boundary spanning as the activity to link and establish relationships between previously unconnected individuals at different MNC units (Barner-Rasmussen *et al.*, 2014; Monteiro and Birkinshaw, 2016).

To deepen our understanding in this matter, this study combines the AMO framework with the literature on boundary spanning. In the next section, the direct relationships between the three dimensions of the AMO framework and knowledge sharing will be elaborated (H1a–H3b), followed by the conceptualization of the moderation effects of inpatriate boundary spanning on these relationships (H4a–H4c).

2.2 Hypotheses

Ability as antecedent of inpatriate knowledge sharing. Ability reflects an individual's general capacity to perform in specific situations (Cummings and Schwab, 1973). In the context of MNCs' knowledge management, ability refers to the knowledge, skills and experience needed to solve difficulties in transferring knowledge between different organizational units across national borders. The inpatriate literature regards international work experience and host-country language proficiency as crucial abilities that facilitate knowledge sharing (Froese *et al.*, 2016; Harvey *et al.*, 2000; Peltokorpi, 2015; Reiche, 2006; Shaffer *et al.*, 1999).

International work experience can support knowledge transfer of MNCs in numerous ways. Internationally experienced employees have been exposed to different cultures, markets and organizational settings (Maley and Kramar, 2014; Takeuchi *et al.*, 2005), making them aware of knowledge developed in one country that may be useful in other host countries of the MNC (Kogut and Zander, 1993). Thus, international work experience enables employees, among others, to transfer knowledge about HQ-subsidiary relations, world-wide business structures, complexities of global operations and characteristics of national markets from one organizational unit to another (Lazarova and Tarique, 2005). While these arguments hold true for expatriates and inpatriates alike, it can be argued that international work experience is of particular relevance for subsidiary employees who work as inpatriates at the HQ. As outlined above, inpatriates are often perceived as less qualified and have less credibility in particular when they come from a technologically and economically less-advanced country (Harvey, Novicevic and Speier, 1999). This ethnocentric perspective of local employees may be less pronounced toward inpatriates with extensive international work experience, a more faceted understanding of diverse organizational processes and a broader set of problem-solving capabilities (Harvey, Novicevic and Speier, 1999; Minbaeva and Michailova, 2004). At the same time, international work experience evokes a higher cultural self-awareness and allows for the selective incorporation of foreign values and practices (Levy *et al.*, 2007). This, in turn may have a positive impact on the inpatriates' respect for and the adaption to foreign cultures and their openness for knowledge exchange (Harveston *et al.*, 2000).

Finally, international work experience will facilitate the cultural adjustment process of the inpatriate to the HQ and thus will hamper the loss of self-efficacy (Harvey, Novicevic and Speier, 1999; Shaffer *et al.*, 1999). Harvey, Novicevic and Speier (1999) outline that in the situations, in which inpatriates experience a devaluation of self-esteem, they may be less able to efficiently share their knowledge regarding culturally and economically distant countries and operations. Based on these considerations, internationally experienced inpatriates will be regarded as more valuable in terms of acquired knowledge and skills and thus, more attractive as partners of knowledge exchange. Thus, it is hypothesized:

H1a. International work experience has a positive effect on inpatriates' knowledge sharing.

A large portion of knowledge in MNCs is embedded in organizational structures, processes and systems and is often only implicitly shared, for example by participation of subsidiary employees in international task forces or by the direct transfer of employees (Rabbiosi, 2011). In order to transfer this knowledge from one unit of the MNC to others, it has to be codified and externalized (Nonaka, 1994). This requires a common language between the sender and receiver of the knowledge transfer (Peltokorpi and Vaara, 2014; Zhang and Peltokorpi, 2015).

Language represents not only an important means of communication, but is also used as an informal source of expert power (Tenzer and Schuster, 2017). For example, assignees' host-country language proficiency is an important prerequisite of successful cultural adjustment (Moeller *et al.*, 2010) and acceptance by host-country employees (Moeller *et al.*, 2016). At the

same time, subsidiary employees who speak the national language of the HQ are often perceived as more competent and occupy more central roles in transnational communication networks (Harzing *et al.*, 2011).

Inpatriates often have a lower social status, face higher adjustment challenges and need to invest more time in order to become adequately socialized into the HQ corporate culture (Moeller *et al.*, 2016; Reiche, 2006). Host-country language proficiency enables inpatriates to more quickly adjust to the local environment, to better communicate with their colleagues, and also strengthens the inpatriates' understanding of the subtleties of the HQ corporate culture (e.g. specific practices and routines). Thus, inpatriates who are fluent in the host-country language can estimate better which knowledge is valuable and acceptable for the HQ. Moreover, local employees will view them as a more valuable source of knowledge than those without host-country language skills (Harzing and Pudelko, 2014). Thus, this study argues that this ability will have a positive influence on inpatriates' knowledge sharing and therefore proposes:

H1b. Host-country language proficiency has a positive effect on inpatriates' knowledge sharing.

Motivation as antecedent of inpatriate knowledge sharing. Beyond ability, the AMO framework highlights the importance of motivation as a driver of behavior and recognizes it as a decisive factor for knowledge sharing (Argote *et al.*, 2003; Minbaeva *et al.*, 2014; Zhang and Peltokorpi, 2015). Motivation determines the direction, intensity and persistence of any action and can be of intrinsic or extrinsic nature (Ryan and Deci, 2000). Osterloh and Frey (2000) highlight that intrinsic motivation is especially important when sharing tacit knowledge, whereas Argote *et al.* (2003) and Kankanhalli *et al.* (2005) point out that organizational rewards such as a higher salary, bonus or promotion are positively related to the frequency of knowledge contribution.

Intrinsic motivation refers to performing an action or behavior for its own sake, out of interest or for enjoyment derived from the experience (Ryan and Deci, 2000). For instance, employees can be satisfied by enhancing their knowledge self-efficacy or confidence by transferring knowledge to colleagues that is useful to the organization (Lin, 2007). Moreover, knowledge-sharing behavior can be regarded as a form of prosocial behavior which is an important aspect of intrinsic motivation (Gagné, 2009).

In the context of international assignees, personal challenge is often considered as an important intrinsic motivation (Reiche, 2006; Stahl *et al.*, 2002). International assignments are more demanding, include a broader task spectrum, and present greater learning opportunities, thus requiring intensive knowledge transfers. Therefore, it is expected that intrinsically motivated inpatriates will more actively engage in knowledge sharing activities. Thus, it is proposed:

H2a. Intrinsic motivation has a positive effect on inpatriates' knowledge sharing.

Extrinsic motivation refers to performing an action or behavior for known or anticipated external rewards, such as a higher salary, bonus or promotion (Ryan and Deci, 2000). In fact, many employees are willing to accept an international assignment because they believe it will help advance their career (Bolino, 2007; Harvey, Novicevic and Speier, 1999; Reiche, 2007; Stahl *et al.*, 2002). Previous research reveals that career development opportunities positively influence knowledge sharing (Lin, 2007). O'Reilly and Pondy (1979) indicate that the probability that organizational members will route information to other members is positively related to the rewards that they expect to gain from knowledge sharing. Subsequent studies have supported the positive relationship between extrinsic motivation and knowledge sharing in MNCs (Gupta and Govindarajan, 2000). Based on these

considerations, it is argued that inpatriates with strong extrinsic motivation will engage in knowledge sharing. Thus, it is proposed:

H2b. Extrinsic motivation has a positive effect on inpatriates' knowledge sharing.

Opportunity as antecedent of inpatriate knowledge sharing. Opportunity broadly refers to organizational mechanisms in contrast to ability and motivation, which are individual-level factors that support individuals in acquiring, retaining and transferring knowledge. According to Chen *et al.* (2010), only including individual-level antecedents of knowledge sharing is not sufficient, as organizational contexts may have a great effect on the creation and exchange of knowledge as well. While opportunities are often conceptualized as constraints (Bendoly and Hur, 2007; Mathieu *et al.*, 1992; Siemsen *et al.*, 2008), this study focuses on organizational mechanisms that could positively affect knowledge transfers across national borders. In the inpatriate literature, mentoring has been described as an important organizational mechanism that is highly influential for knowledge dissemination as it facilitates information processing and internal communication (Feldman and Bolino, 1999; Harvey *et al.*, 2011; Reiche, 2011).

Mentoring can be defined as a one-to-one relationship between a mentor, with advanced experience and knowledge, and a mentee with less experience and knowledge. In the context of international assignments, both home-country and host-country mentors have been proven to positively affect knowledge sharing (Carraher *et al.*, 2008; Mezas and Scandura, 2005; Schuster *et al.*, 2017).

A home-country mentor prepares the mentee for the international assignment and provides on-site vocational and psychosocial support. Staying in permanent contact with a home-country mentor helps inpatriates reduce feelings of isolation, while strengthening the positive attitudes toward the organization (Jassawalla *et al.*, 2006). Moreover, time and effort invested by the home-country mentor may help to increase the assignee's belief that the home organization values them (Carraher *et al.*, 2008). Home-country mentors keep their mentees up to date about developments at home and may also monitor potential job opportunities for the assignee upon his or her return. This in turn increases the inpatriates' commitment to the sending organization. As a result, inpatriates with home-country mentors are likely to more strongly identify themselves with their home organization and thus take pride in sharing their knowledge about this entity with the HQ (Mezas and Scandura, 2005). Based on these considerations it is assumed:

H3a. Home-country mentoring has a positive effect on inpatriates' knowledge sharing.

The main task of host-country mentors is to provide inpatriates with information about the receiving organization, workplace, job requirements, etc., and thus improve their understanding of the new work environment (Carraher *et al.*, 2008). Moreover, they may help inpatriates with personal and family-related issues such as authorizations, housing or schooling. This form of organizational support is likely to increase their identification with the host organization (Mezas and Scandura, 2005). Due to the reciprocal character of mentoring, inpatriates may feel the obligation to repay the support provided by the host-country mentor by sharing their experiences with the host-country organization. Thus, inpatriates with host-country mentors are more likely to engage in knowledge sharing. This study therefore proposes:

H3b. Host-country mentoring has a positive effect on inpatriates' knowledge sharing.

Moderating effects of inpatriate boundary spanning. While the AMO framework focuses on the agents of knowledge transfer (i.e. inpatriates and employees of the home and host organization), the relationship between these agents is not explicitly conceptualized.

Boundary spanning refers to the fact that MNCs consist of various geographically dispersed units that operate under idiosyncratic economic, technical and cultural conditions and that organizational knowledge that exists in a particular unit of the MNC is often instilled with context-specific meaning (Bhagat *et al.*, 2002). Harzing *et al.* (2011) argue in this regard that inpatriates play an important role as bridge individuals as they can overcome language barriers between the HQ staff and the employees in the subsidiaries. They can hereby create linkages between groups in different units that enable future transactions on a broader scale (Reiche, 2011). Inpatriate boundary spanning may therefore function as a catalyst for knowledge sharing in MNCs and amplify the effects of ability, motivation and opportunity on inpatriates' knowledge sharing because of its brokerage function by linking previously unconnected individuals at different units of the MNC (Barner-Rasmussen *et al.*, 2014). Reiche (2011) argue that inpatriates can act as broker between social ties they have established at the HQ and the social ties they maintain at their home unit. By doing so, employees from both the HQ and the subsidiary can subsequently leverage these cross-unit ties for further knowledge exchange. In order to connect previously disconnected individuals, inpatriates' abilities, such as international work experience and host-country language proficiency, are beneficial to share required information. For instance, HQ employees will require information about the subsidiary context and about cultural norms and accepted cultural behaviors to establish a trustful relationship with employees of the foreign subsidiaries (Reiche, 2011). Previous international work experience will help inpatriates to understand which information are useful and required for the HQ employees. Thus, it is expected that inpatriates' abilities are even more useful for knowledge sharing when leveraged by boundary spanning activity. As outlined above, inpatriates can act as bridge individuals to overcome language barriers between previously disconnected individuals and therefore can help to build a trustful relationships between different MNC's units (Harzing *et al.*, 2011; Zhang and Peltokorpi, 2015). We therefore argue that host-country language skills can be even more beneficial for knowledge sharing in situations of high boundary spanning activities.

As motivation turned out to be a crucial factor in the context of boundary spanning (Holtbrügge and Engelhard, 2016), it can be expected that this brokerage has a reinforcing effect on knowledge sharing of motivated inpatriates. Also, organizational support in the form of mentoring should have a stronger effect on knowledge sharing when the inpatriates' possibility and opportunity in form of easier communication and larger social network channels to link previously unconnected individuals at different units of the MNC is high (Kostova and Roth, 2003). Based on these considerations it is proposed:

H4a. Boundary spanning amplifies the relationship between inpatriates' abilities and knowledge sharing.

H4b. Boundary spanning amplifies the relationship between inpatriates' motivation and knowledge sharing.

H4c. Boundary spanning amplifies the relationship between inpatriates' opportunity and knowledge sharing.

Figure 1 illustrates our research model and depicts the respective hypotheses.

3. Methodology

3.1 Sample and procedure

Our hypotheses and overall model proposed above was tested through unique data set obtained from a survey among international assignees working in the HQ of German MNCs. More precisely, the study focused on MNCs headquartered in the Nuremberg

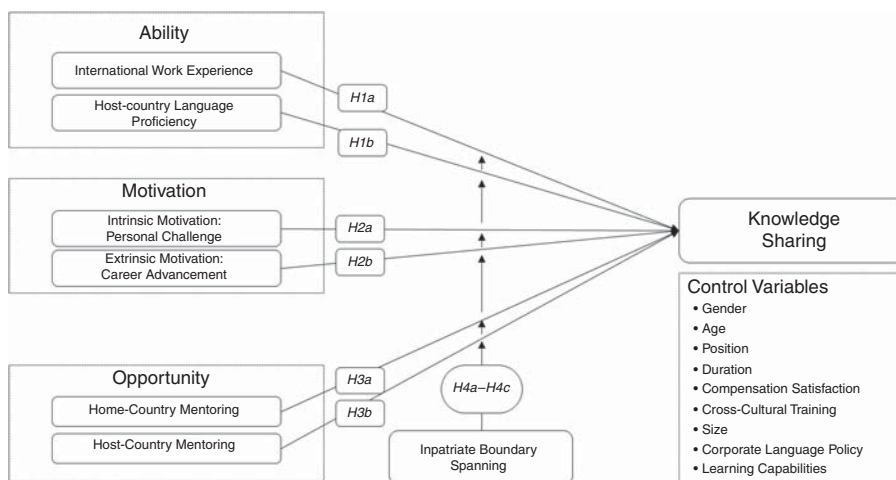


Figure 1.
Research model

Metropolitan Region. This region has a high economic growth and is home to many world-renowned MNCs such as Adidas, Schaeffler and Siemens, as well as medium-sized MNCs including Playmobil, GfK and Faber-Castell. These companies have a high degree of internationalization, operate in a diverse set of industries and employ many foreign employees. This enabled us to approach a large number of inpatriates in various organizational settings and functions. Moreover, this region provides homogeneous working and living conditions for inpatriates, thus potential location effects can be excluded.

The authors sourced contact addresses of inpatriates in the Nuremberg Metropolitan Region in two different ways. First, the authors searched on respective online platforms and social media sites, such as XING, LinkedIn and Just Landed. Second, they contacted the HR departments of firms in the region and asked them to provide us with contact addresses of their inpatriates. This procedure led to 1,005 identified inpatriates. The authors subsequently contacted all identified inpatriates, kindly asked them to participate and provided a token-based link to our online questionnaire. After two weeks, the authors sent out a reminder to all those who had not yet started the survey. In total, 187 usable data sets were received – equaling a response rate of 18.6 percent. The majority (15.3 percent) of the respondents were from India, followed by respondents from the USA (9.1 percent), UK (9.1 percent) and China (8.0 percent). In total, our sample was comprised of inpatriates from 46 different countries. Consistent with our study objectives, we largely focused on inpatriates who are relocated for a limited timeframe of three to five years to the HQ location. Concerning this matter, 80.4 percent of the respondents of our sample indicated that they are on a long-term assignment (three to five years), whereas 19.6 percent indicated that they are either on a short-term assignment, localized or on other assignment type (flexpatriation, commuter assignment, etc.).

The authors followed the recommendations of Armstrong and Overton (1977) and compared returns from early and late respondents (65.2 percent who responded to the first mailing vs the 34.8 percent who responded after the reminder) on all dependent and independent constructs, as well as several control variables. Only one significant difference between early and late respondents with respect to the position of the inpatriate ($p < 0.05$) was found. More specifically, a significant number of inpatriates with higher ranking positions only answered the questionnaire after having received a reminder. Based on the result of the non-response test, non-response bias is determined to not be problematic and used the data without further correction.

To reduce potential common-method bias, the study followed several recommendations suggested by Podsakoff *et al.* (2003) and Chang *et al.* (2010). From an *ex ante* perspective, the authors ensured all respondents complete anonymity and separated independent and dependent constructs in the questionnaire. Moreover, the authors varied different scale endpoints and formats for the predictor and criterion measures in order to minimize potential consistency. From a *post hoc* perspective, the authors computed an exploratory factor analysis and examined the unrotated factor solutions by means of the commonly used Harman single factor test (Harman, 1976; Podsakoff and Organ, 1986). Neither a single factor, nor a general factor accounting for the majority of the covariance emerged in this study based on the unrotated factor solutions. Moreover, the effects of an unmeasured latent method factor were controlled by using AMOS 23.0. The authors introduced a single unmeasured first-order latent method factor to the theoretical model and measured the common-method variance by subtracting standardized regression weights without the common latent factor from standardized regression weights with the common latent factor. Based on these results it is concluded that common-method variance does not play an important role in our findings.

3.2 Measures

All items were measured on the individual level of analysis. Our dependent variable, knowledge sharing, was adopted from Reiche (2011). This was regarded as more appropriate than alternative concepts, such as knowledge transfer performance or effectiveness, because the latter depend on the types (e.g. explicit vs tacit) and conditions (e.g. absorptive capacity) of knowledge sharing, while knowledge sharing is mainly a function of their individual characteristics and organizational conditions (Szulanski, 2000). The measure consists of four items referring to the extent in-patriates shared different types of knowledge with colleagues at the HQ. These include local market knowledge such as formal and informal business norms, knowledge on the political, economic, and social environment of the home country, knowledge on the local subsidiary context and specific knowledge about potential contact people at the home unit (Harvey, Novicevic and Speier, 1999). The four items were measured on a seven-point Likert scale (1 = low effort – 7 = high effort). Since the internal reliability of the construct is very high ($\alpha = 0.92$) (Nunnally and Bernstein, 1978), a composite factor was created by calculating the arithmetical average of all four items.

International work experience was operationalized by using a well-established single item measure in which the respondents indicated the total amount of time they have worked abroad (Brewster *et al.*, 2005; Okpara and Kabongo, 2011).

For host-country language proficiency the authors applied the measure developed by Caligiuri (2000) in which the respondents were asked to describe their ability to speak the language of the host country (German) on a five-point scale ranging from 1 = I do not know the language of this host country to 5 = I am fluent in the language of this host country.

The measurement of extrinsic and intrinsic motivation was based on Stahl *et al.* (2002). The respondents were asked to rate the importance of their motives for accepting the international assignment (1 = not important at all – 7 = extremely important). In line with previous research, “personal challenge” was considered as intrinsic motivation, whereas “future opportunities for advancement” was regarded as extrinsic motivation to accept the international assignment (Haines *et al.*, 2008).

For mentoring, the respondents were asked whether they were assisted by a home-country mentor (a mentor from the foreign subsidiary) or a host-country mentor (a mentor from the German HQ). Both variables were binary coded with 1 = yes and 0 = no (Carraher *et al.*, 2008; Holtbrügge and Ambrosius, 2015).

Inpatriate boundary spanning was measured by using a five-item scale (1 = strongly disagree – 7 = strongly agree) developed by Reiche (2011). The measure builds on existing research on boundary spanning and was particularly developed to reflect the brokering function of inpatriates. A composite factor was created by calculating the arithmetical average of all five items ($\alpha = 0.77$).

Finally, a number of control variables were included (company size, cross-cultural training, compensation satisfaction, time on current assignment, age, gender, learning capability and corporate language policy), which have been utilized in previous studies on international assignments (Caligiuri, 2000; Kuvaas *et al.*, 2012; Moon *et al.*, 2012; Reiche, 2011; Reiche *et al.*, 2011; Varma and Russell, 2016). Company size was measured by asking the respondents to indicate the total number of employees in their organization worldwide. Cross-cultural training was measured with a five-item scale by asking the respondents to indicate on seven-point rating scale the extent to which they had received different types of trainings prior to their assignment (e.g. area studies programs, cultural assimilator training, sensitivity trainings, etc.) (Moon *et al.*, 2012; Tung, 1981). All five items were averaged to create a composite factor ($\alpha = 0.82$). For assessing the satisfaction of the compensation package, a two-item scale from Brewster *et al.* (2005) was adapted. The respondents were asked to indicate on a seven-point rating scale (1 = very dissatisfied – 7 = very satisfied) how satisfied they were with their current net salary and their compensation package as a whole (including bonuses and additional incentives). A composite factor was created by calculating the arithmetical average of both items ($\alpha = 0.82$). Current job position was measured by asking the respondent to indicate his/her current position ranging from (1) non-managerial position (office or technician-type of duties) to (4) top management (vice presidents and directors). Gender is dummy-coded (0 = male, 1 = female); age was self-reported in years; and time on current assignment was self-reported in months. The measure of inpatriates' learning capabilities was based on Mahnke *et al.* (2005) who captured the individual perception of one's ability to understand, learn and acquire new knowledge. The two original items were adapted to the context of the study and a third item was added to account for the inpatriates ability to apply the learned knowledge. Thus, in the applied three-item scale the respondents assessed the following statements concerning their ability to understand, acquire and apply new knowledge during their international assignments. This was rated on a seven-point scale (1 = strongly disagree – 7 = strongly agree): I have the ability to "understand the existing knowledge (technical, managerial, etc.) in the local unit in Germany," "to acquire new knowledge (technical, managerial, etc.) in the local unit in Germany" and "to apply knowledge (technical, managerial, etc.) to new contexts." Again, all three items were averaged to create a composite factor ($\alpha = 0.86$).

Corporate language policy was measured by a binary variable. The respondents were asked to indicate whether their MNC had implemented English as its official corporate language (with 1 = English as formal language policy – 0 = other or no formal language policy) (Peltokorpi and Vaara, 2014).

4. Results

The descriptive results show that 67 percent of the inpatriates are male with an average age of 34.42, an average time on the current assignment of 31.69 months, and average international work experience of 41.92 months (Table I). Multicollinearity was tested by evaluating the variance inflation factors (VIF) of all variables. The VIF of the control and independent variables as well as interaction terms ranged between 1.03 and 3.61 and thus are substantially lower than the recommended threshold of 10 (Hair *et al.*, 2006). Therefore, it was concluded that there is no serious multicollinearity effect. To test the hypotheses, a hierarchical multiple (moderated) regression analysis was applied. Following the

Table 1.
Descriptive statistics
and correlations

	Mean	SD	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1. Gender	0.333	0.473	1								
2. Age	34.424	7.648	-0.296***	1							
3. Time on current assignment	31.687	33.016	-0.088	0.365***	1						
4. Current job position	2.943	0.885	0.103	-0.436***	-0.229**	1					
5. Compensation satisfaction	4.408	1.271	-0.018	-0.010	-0.148*	0.008	1				
6. Cross-cultural training	2.183	1.348	0.006	0.009	-0.105	0.091	0.073	1			
7. Company size	148.854	154.925	-0.152***	0.140***	0.097	0.241**	0.064	0.001	1		
8. International work experience	41.922	41.885	-0.108	0.440***	0.764***	-0.350***	-0.090	-0.058	0.019	1	
9. Host-country language proficiency	3.536	1.217	0.043	0.091	0.215***	0.147***	0.045	0.176*	0.164*	0.236**	1
10. Learning capabilities	5.967	1.019	-0.084	0.096	0.144***	-0.005	0.136***	0.063	0.126	0.235**	0.124***
11. Intrinsic motivation	5.968	1.073	-0.011	0.014	-0.055	0.028	-0.008	0.139***	0.108	0.006	-0.054
12. Extrinsic motivation	6.104	1.008	0.007	-0.114	0.070	-0.019	0.097	0.040	0.030	0.134***	0.058
13. Home-country mentor	0.733	0.444	-0.122	0.076	0.022	-0.113	0.001	-0.151*	-0.236**	0.048	-0.208**
14. Host-country mentor	0.385	0.488	0.034	-0.109	-0.242**	0.148***	0.150*	0.100	0.230**	-0.306***	0.015
15. Corporate language policy	0.601	0.491	0.148***	-0.132***	-0.052	0.251**	0.108	0.153*	0.111	-0.061	0.085
16. Inpatriate boundary spanning	4.986	1.240	-0.013	0.082	-0.019	-0.043	0.268***	0.182*	0.140***	0.047	-0.001
17. Knowledge sharing	3.484	1.620	-0.007	0.044	-0.158*	-0.112	0.086	0.129***	-0.060	-0.159*	-0.064
	Mean	SD	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	
1. Gender	0.333	0.473									
2. Age	34.424	7.648									
3. Time on current assignment	31.687	33.016									
4. Current job position	2.943	0.885									
5. Compensation satisfaction	4.408	1.271									
6. Cross-cultural training	2.183	1.348									
7. Company size	148.854	154.925									
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13. Home-country mentor	0.733	0.444									
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15. Corporate language policy	0.601	0.491									
16. Inpatriate boundary spanning	4.986	1.240									
17. Knowledge sharing	3.484	1.620									

Notes: $n = 187$. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$; **** $p < 0.10$

recommendations of Aiken and West (1991), we standardized all control, independent and moderator variables (dummy variables excluded) before calculating the respective interaction terms. Moreover, as recommended by Aiken and West (1991), we included the respective interaction terms in separate regression models. In general, we conducted our analysis in different steps as employed in previous research in the inpatriate literature (Froese *et al.*, 2016; Reiche, 2011). In the first step, the nine control variables were entered. In the second step, our six independent variables with regard to abilities, motivation and opportunities were included in order to examine the main effects. In the third step, we included the inpatriate boundary spanning as moderator as well as the interaction terms in separate models to examine each effect individually.

The results of the regression models are presented in Table II. The control model (control variables only) only explains a small share of the variance in knowledge sharing of inpatriates (adj. $R^2 = 0.042$, $p < 0.10$). Only “time on the current assignment” ($\beta = -0.176$, $p < 0.05$), “current job position” ($\beta = 0.224$, $p < 0.01$) and “cross-cultural training” ($\beta = 0.131$, $p < 0.10$) have a significant effect on the inpatriates’ knowledge sharing, whereas gender, age, compensation satisfaction, company size, learning capabilities and corporate language proficiency are insignificant. In our base model, all independent variables were added, which cover abilities, motivation and opportunities. These variables make a significant contribution over and above the control model (adj. $R^2 = 0.158$, $p < 0.001$). The results in the base model indicate that host-country language proficiency ($\beta = -0.145$, $p < 0.10$) and having a host-country mentor ($\beta = -0.166$, $p < 0.05$) have a negative effect, whereas the extrinsic motive career advantage ($\beta = 0.199$, $p < 0.05$) as well as having a home-country mentor ($\beta = 0.244$, $p < 0.01$) show a positive effect on inpatriates’ knowledge sharing. In order to test the moderating effects, the recommendations of Aiken and West (1991) were followed and we included the standardized moderator variable and the respective interaction terms. The coefficients of the independent variables only slightly change in Models 1–6 in which the moderation effects are included, indicating a certain robustness of the effects.

In Model 1, the moderating effect of inpatriate boundary spanning on the relationship between international work experience and knowledge sharing was analyzed. A significant increase of the explained variance (adj. $R^2 = 0.213$, $p < 0.001$) can be seen compared to our base model. The results of Model 1 reveal a significant negative interaction effect of boundary spanning on the relationship between international work experience and knowledge sharing ($\beta = -0.238$, $p < 0.01$). Whereas Models 2–4 show no significant increase of the explained variance with non-significant moderating effects, Model 5 (adj. $R^2 = 0.184$, $p < 0.001$) as well as Model 6 (adj. $R^2 = 0.191$, $p < 0.001$) reveal positive moderating effects for home-country mentors ($\beta = 0.150$, $p < 0.10$) and host-country mentors ($\beta = 0.246$, $p < 0.05$).

5. Discussion

In *H1a* and *H1b* we argued that international work experience and host-country language proficiency have positive effects on inpatriates’ knowledge sharing. Contrary to the hypothesized direction, the results of the regression analysis reveal negative effects of the two abilities on knowledge sharing, albeit on a non-significant or marginal significant level. Hence, *H1a–H1b* have to be rejected.

The body of inpatriate literature provides potential explanations why the basic rationale proposed by the AMO framework may not hold true in the inpatriate context. It is argued that inpatriates lack in reputation and credibility because they are perceived as outsiders or peripheral members by the HQ staff and because of the ethnocentric stigmatization and stereotyping toward them (Harvey *et al.*, 2005; Reiche, Harzing and Kraimer, 2009). The rationale behind this logic is that inpatriates in contrast to their expatriate counterparts are

Table II.
Regression results on
knowledge sharing

	Control model	Base model	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4	Model 5	Model 6
Intercept	4.209***	4.300***	4.355***	4.314***	4.315***	4.312***	4.306***	4.244***
<i>Control variables</i>								
Gender	0.070	0.093	0.105	0.090	0.086	0.086	0.089	0.096
Age	-0.0264	0.058	0.055	0.046	0.041	0.052	0.058	0.072
Time on current assignment	-0.176*	-0.015	-0.045	-0.010	-0.016	-0.010	0.002	-0.028
Current job Position	0.224**	0.157***	0.123	0.153***	0.156***	0.149***	0.168*	0.138
Compensation satisfaction	0.046	0.036	0.029	0.006	0.002	0.006	0.001	-0.010
Cross-cultural training	0.131***	0.132***	0.088	0.110	0.109	0.107	0.102	0.105
Company size	0.117	0.045	0.039	0.038	0.034	0.040	0.035	0.023
Learning capabilities	-0.051	-0.069	-0.125***	-0.099	-0.103	-0.099	-0.112	-0.092
Corporate language policy	-0.012	-0.052	-0.060	-0.041	-0.042	-0.038	-0.051	-0.036
<i>Independent variables</i>								
Ability								
International work experience		-0.120	0.025	-0.133	-0.126	-0.129	-0.148	-0.137
Host-country language proficiency		-0.145***	-0.151*	-0.130***	-0.127***	-0.131***	-0.113	-0.114
Motivation								
Intrinsic motivation		0.117	0.098	0.109	0.123	0.107	0.116	0.084
Extrinsic motivation		0.199*	0.184*	0.179*	0.177*	0.177*	0.175*	0.188*
Opportunity								
Home-country mentor		0.244**	0.219**	0.206*	0.212**	0.209*	0.195*	0.195*
Host-country mentor		-0.166*	-0.169*	-0.162*	-0.172*	-0.158*	-0.163*	-0.143***
<i>Moderator variable and interaction terms</i>								
Inpatient boundary spanning (IBS)			0.207**	0.163*	0.161*	0.166*	0.075	-0.032
IBS × International work experience			-0.238**					
IBS × Host-country language proficiency				-0.015				
IBS × Intrinsic motivation					0.057	-0.035		
IBS × Extrinsic motivation								
IBS × Home-country mentor							0.150***	0.246*
IBS × Host-country mentor								0.191
Adjusted R ²	0.042	0.158	0.213	0.171	0.174	0.172	0.184	0.265
Unadjusted R ²	0.088	0.226	0.285	0.247	0.249	0.247	0.258	0.303*
Δ R ²		0.140***	0.059**	0.021	0.023	0.022***	0.033*	0.039*
Model F-value	1.909****	3.326***	3.957***	3.253***	3.301***	3.269***	3.461***	3.575***

Notes: n = 187. *p < 0.05; **p < 0.01; ***p < 0.001; ****p < 0.10

associated with the reputation and status of their home units, which are commonly less strategically relevant for the entire MNC than the HQ. In fact, the inpatriate literature outlines that expatriates typically carry with them the status and reputation associated with their role as representatives of the HQ, which is generally the center of decision making and the most important unit of the MNC. Thus, being identifying and associated with the HQ will enhance the expatriate's individual reputation in the foreign subsidiary (reputational gain) (Kostova and Roth, 2003), which in turn leads to the expatriate being more inclined to share knowledge on the HQ with the foreign subsidiary staff (Inkpen and Tsang, 2005; Lazaroova and Tarique, 2005). This is because engaging in knowledge sharing will result in a stronger association with the HQ, so that the expatriate can benefit from the reputational status of the HQ.

On the contrary, inpatriates are delegated to the HQ from a foreign subsidiary that is regularly less strategically relevant for the entire MNC. It is smaller than the HQ and possesses a lower level of resources and capabilities. Thus, being associated with the less powerful home subsidiary will lower the inpatriates' individual reputation and social capital in the HQ (reputational loss) (Harvey *et al.*, 2005; Millar and Choi, 2009). The reputational gain of expatriates, e.g. benefiting from being associated with the powerful HQ and the reputational loss of inpatriates, e.g. being penalized by being associated with the less powerful home unit can be understood as a reputation asymmetry between these two employee groups, which influence their behavior concerning knowledge sharing.

Based on our findings, we speculate that this reputation asymmetry between expatriates and inpatriates influences the effect of the assignees' abilities on knowledge sharing. Inpatriates with extensive international work experience have spent a longer period of time in other countries and are thus aware of cultural and organizational differences. This cosmopolitan socialization is likely to reduce their identification with a particular country or MNC unit (Black *et al.*, 1991). However, sharing knowledge about their home market will increase the association with the less powerful subsidiary and will cause the reputational loss.

The reputation asymmetry between HQs and subsidiary may also explain the significant negative effect of language proficiency on inpatriates' knowledge sharing. Host-country language proficiency not only facilitates inpatriates' communication with HQ employees, but also allows them to adapt more easily to the host-country organization (Black *et al.*, 1991). Thus, fluency in the local language reduces the inpatriates' psychic distance to the HQs and the local employees' ethnocentric attitudes toward them. Inpatriates fluent in the host-country language perceive a higher acceptance, reputation and social capital in the HQ. Thus, with a high host-country language fluency of the inpatriate, the HQ staff may less strongly associate the inpatriates with the less powerful foreign subsidiary. In order to not risk this perception (e.g. being less associated with the home unit), inpatriates may reduce their engagement in sharing knowledge about their home unit and market.

In *H2a* and *H2b*, it is proposed that intrinsic and extrinsic motivation is positively related to knowledge sharing. As only the extrinsic motive, career advancement, shows a significant effect, *H2b* can be confirmed, while the coefficients for personal challenge reflecting intrinsic motivation are insignificant in all models. Again, this finding may be explained by the reputation asymmetry between the home and host organization. Inpatriates who are strongly motivated by future career opportunities in the MNC are inclined to maintain close relationships with colleagues in both the HQ and the subsidiary and will therefore engage in knowledge sharing between the two units. On the contrary, strong ties with their home organization are less valuable for inpatriates who are primarily motivated by personal challenges. Close relationships with the home-country may even reduce their reputation and social capital in the HQ. Thus, inpatriates with strong intrinsic motivation will less engage in knowledge sharing compared to inpatriates with strong extrinsic motivation.

In *H3a* and *H3b*, it is argued that the opportunities offered by the organizations positively affect knowledge sharing. While the results reveal that home-country mentoring is significantly positive in all models, surprisingly, host-country mentoring shows negative effects on knowledge sharing. Therefore, *H3a–H3b* can only be partially supported.

Based on the concept of reputation asymmetry, we speculate that organizational support by a host-country mentor (e.g. a mentor of the HQ) gives inpatriates the opportunity to adjust more quickly to the HQ culture (Maley *et al.*, 2015). Moreover, the attention they receive from the HQ in form of being mentored by experienced HQ managers signals their value for the HQ and reduces the HQ staff's ethnocentric attitudes toward the inpatriates (Reiche, 2011). Thus, being connected with the host-country mentor may lead to a reputational gain of the inpatriates and lowers the association with less powerful foreign subsidiary. As a consequence, the inpatriates' reputation at and identification with the HQ increases, while their identification with the subsidiary decreases. This in turn decreases their propensity to engage in knowledge as this will increase the association with the less powerful subsidiary.

In *H4a*, it is argued that inpatriate boundary spanning has a reinforcing effect on the relationship between inpatriates' abilities and knowledge sharing. While a significant moderating effect of inpatriate boundary spanning for international work experience was found, the effects of German language proficiency on knowledge sharing are not affected. Figure 2 illustrates the significant moderating effect of boundary spanning on the relationship between international work experience and knowledge sharing and shows that high inpatriate boundary spanning reduces knowledge sharing with increasing international work experience, whereas for low boundary spanning a positive interaction effect is revealed.

Based on these results, it seems plausible to argue that in order to connect individuals from different organizational units and cultures, inpatriates have to exchange information concerning the unique context of their home units and markets. Reiche (2011, p. 366) outlines in this regard that inpatriate boundary spanning requires to “provide HQ staff with context-specific knowledge about the subsidiary environment to ensure that HQ employees can benefit from future exchanges with subsidiary staff.” Inpatriates with international work experience will know more precisely which contextual knowledge is necessary and which not. Being more efficient in providing contextual knowledge may explain the observed lower engagement in knowledge sharing.

In *H4b*, it is argued that boundary spanning will reinforce the relationship between motivation and knowledge sharing. The results show no differences between low and high boundary spanning. Intrinsic and extrinsic motivations have similar positive effects on knowledge sharing for high and low boundary spanners.

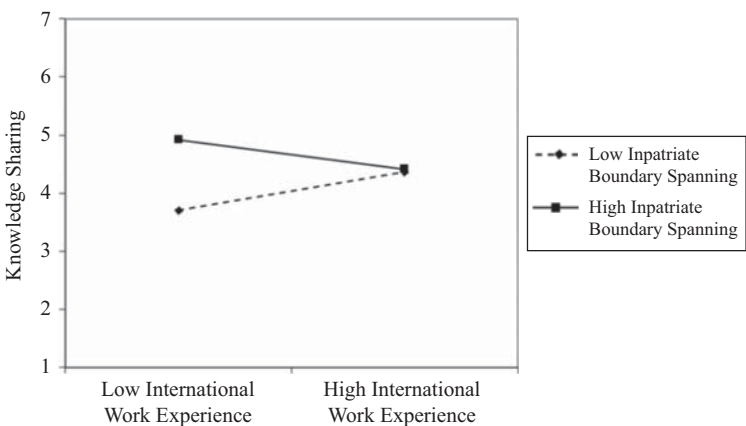


Figure 2.
International work
experience and
knowledge sharing at
low and high levels of
boundary spanning

The findings only partially support *H4c*. With regard to home-country mentoring, one can see significant differences between low and high boundary spanners. As proposed, having a home-country mentor will strengthen the inpatriates identification with their home unit, which will lead to higher knowledge sharing (Figure 3).

For host-country mentors, a significant positive interaction term was found, while the direct relationship between host-country mentoring and knowledge sharing is negative. Figure 4 illustrates this finding and outlines that the negative influence of host-country mentoring on knowledge sharing can only be found for low inpatriate boundary spanning. However, a host-country mentor only marginally affects knowledge sharing in the case of high inpatriate boundary spanning. As argued above, host-country mentoring leads to an increase of the inpatriates' reputation at and identification with the HQ, which in turn decreases their knowledge sharing. This negative effect on knowledge sharing is obviously lower when the inpatriates' inclination to connect previously unconnected individuals in the HQ and the subsidiary is high.

6. Conclusions

6.1 Theoretical and empirical contributions

Our study contributes to the literature on international assignments and knowledge sharing in various ways. First, this study extends the scarce empirical evidence on the inpatriation

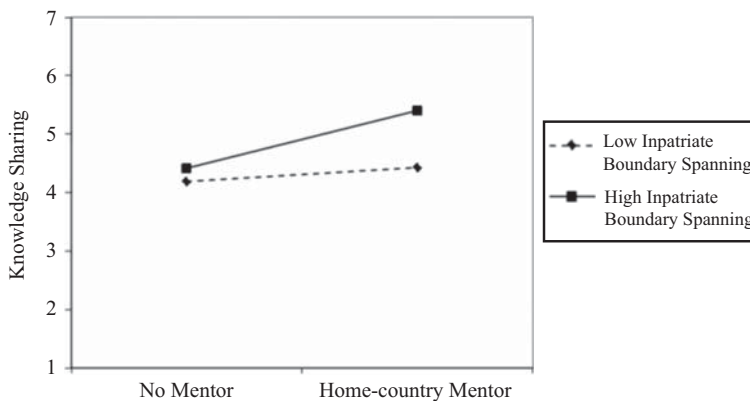


Figure 3.
Home-country mentor
and knowledge
sharing at low and
high levels of
boundary spanning

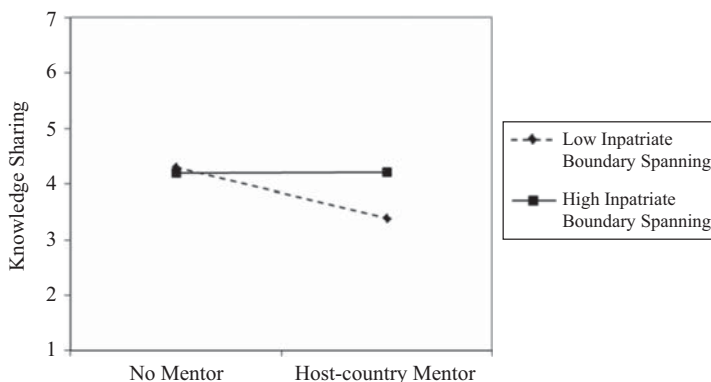


Figure 4.
Host-country mentor
and knowledge
sharing efforts at low
and high levels of
boundary spanning

phenomenon in particular, regarding inpatriates' role as knowledge agents, a topic that is becoming more important as MNCs are likely to increase their share of inpatriates in the future (Maley and Moeller, 2018; Moeller and Reiche, 2017). While previous studies in this context analyzed, for example, the effect of different functional areas and categories of international assignees or the influence of language and cultural intelligence (Froese *et al.*, 2016; Reiche *et al.*, 2015), this study extends this literature by examining antecedents of knowledge sharing and the impact of inpatriate boundary spanning. Furthermore, this study extends on current research by employing the AMO framework in combination with boundary spanning which has only recently been applied in the expatriate literature (Chang *et al.*, 2012; Reinholt *et al.*, 2011) and has never been transferred to the inpatriation context.

Our study provide empirical evidence and support the arguments in the extant body of literature that expatriation and inpatriation in the context of knowledge sharing needs to be differentiated due to differing challenges and mechanisms between these groups of international assignees. In fact, the study reveals that certain inpatriates' abilities do not positively affect knowledge sharing, whereas motivation and certain opportunities have a positive influence. By introducing the concept of boundary spanning as a moderator, the study is able to outline divergent effects of abilities (international work experience) and opportunities (mentoring) on knowledge sharing. More generally, as certain aspects of the AMO framework have divergent effects on knowledge sharing, the study reveals that it may be too simplistic to transfer the results of the expatriate literature to inpatriates and emphasize to more specifically consider the differences between these two groups of international assignees.

An important theoretical contribution in this context is the introduction of the reputation asymmetry concept. While expatriates perceive a reputation gain when delegated to a foreign subsidiary, the identification of inpatriates with their home organization is likely to reduce their reputation at the HQ. Thus, inpatriates' abilities, such as international work experience and host-country language proficiency may negatively impact knowledge sharing. Similarly, organizational support by a host-country mentor increases their reputation at the HQ and reduces the inpatriates' propensity to engage in these transfers. Our second theoretical contribution lies in the identification of inpatriate boundary spanning as contextual variable. Therefore, our study extends on Reiche (2011) by incorporating a moderating role of inpatriate boundary spanning in the context of reverse knowledge transfer. Furthermore, the authors identify inpatriate boundary spanning solely as a linking function in this study, while other functions such as knowledge exchanging, intervening or facilitating remain to be examined by further research. In a more general sense, the introduction of the reputation asymmetry concept contributes to the current debate on distance measures in international management (Harzing and Pudelko, 2016; Shenkar, 2012). In line with research scholars who advise caution when using the national cultural index as proxy for differences between units from different countries (Ambos and Håkanson, 2014; Mezas *et al.*, 2002), it is emphasized that distance measures should not only include cultural, geographical and language differences, but also reputation differences. Particularly in the context of international assignments, the reputation of countries and organizational units is likely to influence assignees' attitudes and behavior (Håkanson *et al.*, 2016). Second, reputation – like any other perception concept – should be measured on an individual level and take individual differences into account. As our study shows, the transfer from a subsidiary to the HQ may have different reputation effects for inpatriates as compared to expatriates. Third, future conceptualizations of reputation should distinguish between the reputation of countries and those of organizational units. While the reputation of countries includes factors, such as advanced economy, appealing environment and effective government (Reputation Institute, 2018), the reputation of organizational units is more a function of their relevance for the entire MNC and their level of autonomy.

Finally, reputation should be conceptualized as an asymmetric phenomenon. As our study shows, the reputation effect of a delegation from the HQ to a peripheral unit may be asymmetric to the reputation effect of the reverse delegation.

6.2 Managerial implications

Our findings have important practical implications as well. MNCs should be aware that inpatriates with strong abilities are not automatically inclined to engage in knowledge sharing. In contrast, they may hide abilities which identify them with their home organization because this reduces their reputation at the HQ. Therefore, MNCs should signal to HQ staff that inpatriates can be valuable sources of knowledge in order to reduce collective reservation and to prevent ethnocentric stigmatization and stereotyping. One way to increase the status and social capital of the inpatriate at the HQ is the provision of a host-country mentor. Moreover, MNCs should actively support the inpatriates propensity to share their personal contacts in the subsidiary with managers in the HQ.

Another important practical implication relates to the selection of inpatriates. Our study shows that inpatriates who primarily accept delegations to HQ for extrinsic motivations have a higher tendency to engage in knowledge sharing. Thus, MNCs that seek to increase these transfers should select subsidiary employees who have particularly strong career-related motives. On the contrary, intrinsically motivated inpatriates are less suitable for this task.

6.3 Limitations and future research

The study is not without limitations. First, while the study outlined the importance of reverse knowledge transfers for MNCs, the authors actually measured knowledge sharing. While knowledge sharing is a required antecedent of successful knowledge transfers, the latter also depends on the knowledge characteristics (teachability, tacitness, codifiability and complexity), the relational aspects between knowledge sender and receiver (trust, power, position and reliability), and the characteristics of the knowledge receiver (absorptive capacity, past experiences and cultural intelligence). Thus, future research would benefit from taking these conditions of knowledge transfer into account. Similarly, distinguishing between the sources of transferrable knowledge (e.g. internal knowledge and network knowledge) could be an alley for future research (Foss and Pedersen, 2002). Moreover, as Barner-Rasmussen *et al.* (2014) already pointed to more faceted roles of boundary spanning (e.g. exchanging, linking, facilitating and intervening), another avenue for future research could be to split up the boundary spanning concept into different dimensions and to analyze their relevance for inpatriates' knowledge sharing.

Second, our sample consists of inpatriates who are temporarily relocated to the HQ in one specific metropolitan region in Germany (Nuremberg Metropolitan Region). Comparing our sample with the conceptualization of inpatriates in the extant literature, it is important to mention that the inpatriates in our sample may not be representative for the broad and diverse population of inpatriates described in the literature. In fact, our sample is widely restricted to relatively young and less experienced inpatriates, a fact that may partly explain findings that contradict the arguments in the inpatriate literature. Therefore, one needs to be cautious when transferring the findings to experienced inpatriate managers in top management positions. Moreover, while focusing on one specific region comes along with the important advantage of keeping possible location influences constant, the findings may not be transferable to other contexts. Therefore, future studies should include a more diverse set of inpatriates (experienced vs unexperienced, top management position vs specialists) and home and host countries with different technological, economic and cultural conditions. This would also allow for analyzing the proposed reputation asymmetry effect in more detail. For similar reasons,

future research should include subsidiaries with different size, resources and strategic relevance for the entire MNC and test whether these organizational attributes affect knowledge sharing efforts of inpatriates as well. Finally, it would be interesting to compare the antecedents of knowledge sharing of inpatriates and those of returned expatriates. While our study indicates several important differences, our sample only included inpatriates and therefore did not allow us to formally test these differences.

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